

GENDER – ADVANCED LEVEL

❖ Topic overview

- Sex and gender
 - Gender roles
 - Social construction of gender roles
 - Female and male roles
 - Theories of gender
 - Gender policy in Zimbabwe
 - Women and employment
-

❖ INTRODUCTION

In the book of Genesis, the Lord said:

“I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children; and thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee.” Genesis 3:16.

Sociologists would regard the above quotation as a mythological justification for the position of women in society.

In recent decades, particularly with the rise of feminist ideas, the explanation for gender differences has been hotly debated.

❖ SEX AND GENDER

Sociologists suggest that the differences between men and women are as much social as biological. The first person to make this distinction was Stoller (1968).

Stoller cautioned against the assumption that biological differences are responsible for the differences in both the behaviour of men and women and the roles that they play in society.

He argues:

“Gender is a term that has psychological and cultural connotations; if the proper terms for sex are ‘male’ and ‘female’, the corresponding terms for gender are ‘masculine’ and ‘feminine’; these latter might be quite independent of (biological) sex.” Stoller (1968).

This means that being a woman does not necessarily means being 'feminine', nor that being a man means behaving in a 'masculine' way; girls are not necessarily caring and compassionate; boys do not have to be aggressive and competitive.

- Sex

Sex refers to the biological differences between men and women i.e. physical characteristics: 'external genitalia, gonads (organs which produce sex cells), hormonal states and secondary sex characteristics – which makes women capable of bearing and suckling children, whereas men are not.

Sexism is discrimination against people based on their sex or gender. Sexism can refer to three subtly different beliefs or attitudes:

- The belief that one sex is superior to the other.
- The belief that men and women are very different and that this should be strongly reflected in society, language, the right to have sex, and the law.
- It can also refer to simple hatred of men (**misandry**) or women (**misogyny**).

- Gender

Gender refers to the socially constructed roles which men and women are expected to perform.

Gender is social, not biological.

❖ GENDER ROLES

- Social construction of gender roles

Oakley (1974) believes that gender roles are culturally rather than biologically produced i.e. whatever biological differences between men and women, it is the culture of a society that exerts most influence in the creation of masculine and feminine behaviour. If there are biological tendencies for men and women to behave differently, these can be overridden by cultural factors.

Oakley outlined how socialisation shapes the behaviour of girls and boys from an early age:

- a) Manipulation

The child's self-concept is affected by manipulation e.g. mothers tend to pay more attention to girls' hair and to dress them in 'feminine' clothes.

b) Canalisation

This involves the direction of boys and girls towards different objects e.g. the provision of toys – which encourage girls to rehearse their expected adult roles as mothers and housewives. Girls are given dolls, soft toys etc. boys are given toys like bricks and guns which encourage more practical, logical and aggressive behaviour.

c) Verbal appellations

It involves use of verbal appellations such as '...a naughty boy.' Or '...good girl.'

This leads young children to imitate adults of the same gender.

d) Exposure to different activities

Boys and girls are exposed to different activities e.g. girls are encouraged to be involved with domestic tasks.

• **Female and male gender roles**

Examples of female roles include: child care, cooking, gathering etc.

Examples of male roles include: hunting

- Female roles are 'expressive' in nature – meaning she provides warmth, security and emotional support (which is effective for the socialisation of the young) whereas male roles are 'instrumental in nature – spend the day competing in an achievement oriented society (Parsons 1955).
- Female roles are less strenuous than male roles.

Sex and gender differences – conclusion

Biology and culture – bodies and the social meaning attributed to them – are interconnected and it is difficult, or even impossible, to separate the two elements out. For example, Connell (2002) sees biology and culture as 'fused' together.

❖ **THEORIES OF GENDER DIFFERENCES**

• **Introduction**

Two schools of thought constitute the debate on explaining gender differences between men and women i.e. Biology and socialisation. This constitutes the nature–nature debate.

• **Biological makeup**

Hormones

- Hormones are bodily secretions whose function include the regulation of the development of male and female bodies so that they are capable of reproduction. The production of hormones is controlled by the hypothalamus in the brain.
- Normally women produce greater amounts of progesterone and oestrogen, while men produce more testosterone and other androgens.
- The activity of a variety of hormones can influence behaviour, personality and emotional disposition
- Animal research has been used to link androgens and aggressive behaviour. For example, castrated males rats/ or monkeys tend to fight less, while female rats/or monkeys given extra androgens after birth are more aggressive than other female rats. Some studies seem to show a direct link between testosterone levels in human males and aggression.

Critic

Sociologists argue that aggressiveness has more to do with masculinity than hormones

Brain lateralisation – (Nicholson, 1993)

- According to Nicholson et al, the right and left hemispheres of the brain specialise in different tasks i.e. in about 95% of the population, the left hemisphere specialises in verbal and language skills, while the right hemisphere is mainly responsible for visuo-spatial abilities, which relate to the ‘ability to locate objects in space.’
- Grayn and Buffery (1971) believe that the left hemisphere of the brain is more dominant in girls after the age of two, and that boys have greater abilities in those functions concentrated in the right hemisphere.
- This may account for the results of some tests which appear to show that girls have greater verbal ability than boys, but boys perform better in spatial and mathematical tests.

Socio-biology – evolution of human behaviour

- This attempts to relate sex differences to differences in behaviour of men and women using evolutionary ideas, basing in part on Darwin’s theory.

- Humans develop and change through a process of natural selection, individuals of a species vary in their physical characteristics, and those which are best adapted to the environment are most likely to survive and reproduce.
- Sociologists argue that it is not just physical characteristics that evolve, but also behaviour.
- Different reproductive strategies produce different behaviour in males and females and also lead them to occupy different social roles. For example in terms of sexual behaviour, men are likely to be more promiscuous, while women are more cautious in their pursuit of the possible genetic partner.

Biology and practicality – (Murdock, 1949)

- Murdock believed that biological differences such as greater physical strength of men and the fact that women bear children, lead to differences in gender roles out of sheer practicality. Murdock stated
‘...men with his superior physical strength can better undertake the more strenuous tasks...’
- In a cross cultural survey of 224 societies, ranging from hunting and gathering groups to modern societies, Murdock found tasks such as hunting, mining and lumbering to be predominantly male roles, and cooking , fetching water and making and repairing clothes to be largely female roles.

Biology and the ‘expressive’ female (Parsons, 1955)

- Parsons characterised the woman’s role in the family as ‘expressive’, which means she provides warmth, security and emotional support, which is essential for effective socialisation of the young
- The male bread winner spent his working day competing in an achievement – oriented society. This ‘instrumental’ role leads to stress and anxiety. The expressive female relieves this tension by providing the weary breadwinner with love, consideration and understanding.

Chromosomes

Men have XY chromosomes whereas women have XX chromosomes. These are believed to account for differences in behaviour between men and women e.g. aggressiveness.

• Socialisation

This approach rejects the view that gender differences are a result of biological makeup:

Cultural division of labour – Oakley

- Oakley rejects the views of Parsons and Murdock, saying there is no natural or inevitable division of labour or allocation of social roles on the basis of sex.
- According to Oakley, culture determines gender roles and the mother – housewife role I.e. whatever the biological differences between males and females, it is the culture of a society that exerts most influence in the creation of masculine and feminine behaviour. If there are biological tendencies for men and women to behave in different ways, these can be outweighed by cultural factors.

Gender role socialisation (Liberal feminism)

Gender roles are socially constructed through the socialisation process e.g. family, education, and media.

- Gender role socialisation by various institutions is responsible for reproducing a sexual division of labour in which masculinity is seen as dominant and femininity as subordinate.
- The main reason for the subordination of women in the labour market is the dominance of the mother – housewife role for women (Oakley).

Critic

- It implies women passively accept their gender identities and underestimates the degree of resistance of women.

- It fails to acknowledge that women's experiences differ according to social class and race.
- Does not explain why masculinity and femininity (as socially constructed) lead to men dominating and women being oppressed.

Culture and the devaluation of women (Ortner, 1974)

According to Ortner, it is not biology as such that assigns women to their status in society, but the way in which every culture defines and evaluates female biology.

The biological family – Radical feminist view (Firestone, 1970)

- Biological differences produce a form of social organisation she calls the 'biological family'. Although societies vary in the roles of men and women, all societies share the **biological family**, which has four characteristics:
 - Women are disadvantaged by their biology e.g. menstruation, menopause, childbirth, pregnancy and breastfeeding which all have the most serious social consequences.
 - Women's dependence on men is increased by the long periods during which human infants are dependent, compared to the infants of other species.
 - The interdependence between mother and child, and in turn their dependence on men, has been found in every society and has influenced the psychology of every human being. Dependence on men produce unequal power relationships and **power psychology**.
 - The biological family provides the foundations for all types of inequality and stratification.

Since sexual class has a biological origin, biological equality is the starting point for securing its elimination. Firestone believes that effective birth control techniques help loosen the chains of women's slavery by giving them more control over whether they become pregnant.

Even so, contraceptives have not freed women from pregnancy altogether, this would be possible if babies could be conceived and develop outside the womb.

Rational choice theory (Hakim)

- According to Hakim, women are not victims of unfair employment practises, or patriarchy, but rather they make rational choices in terms of the type of work they do e.g. most women choose part time work etc.

Critic

- Too often, it is the employer's attitude rather than women's attitudes that confine women to the secondary labour market.

Patriarchy (Walby)

- Walby developed the concept of patriarchy to explain gender stratification. According to Walby (1990), "patriarchy" is indispensable for an analysis of gender inequality.'
- She offers a different definition of patriarchy from other feminists saying that there are six patriarchal structures which restrict women and help maintain male dominance:
 - o Paid work
 - o Patriarchal relations within the household
 - o Patriarchal culture
 - o Sexuality
 - o Male violence towards women
 - o The state

According to Walby, patriarchy has three elements:

- Subordination – patriarchal institutions e.g. family, inevitably produce unequal relations between men and women.
- Oppression – women experience sexism because men discriminate against them on the basis of unfounded stereotypes or ideologies.
- Exploitation – men exploit women's skills and labour without rewarding them sufficiently e.g. in the home and at the workplace.

Industrialisation and the creation of 'housewife' (Marxist feminism)

Capitalist ideologies locate women in the home e.g. the idea that married women have less rights to a job than men is common among management, unions and women themselves. Oakley points out that Industrialisation led to the creation of 'housewife'.

Dual labour market theory (Barron and Norris, 1976)

- The primary labour market is characterised by high pay, job security, good working conditions and favourable promotion prospects.
- The secondary labour market consists of lower paid jobs with less job security, inferior working conditions and few opportunities for promotion.
- Women are likely than men to be found in the secondary – labour market because employers subscribe to stereotypical beliefs about the unsuitability of women.
- Promotion streams are organised in ways that match the life experiences of men better than women because employers demand continuous service.
- Neo Weberian sociologists argue that women experience 'status inequality' because of patriarchy. Women with the same qualifications as men will continue to be disadvantaged as long as these two labour markets continue to exist

Critic

- Bradley points out that Barron and Norris fail to explain inequalities in the same sector e.g. teaching is not a secondary labour market job yet women are less likely than men to gain high status positions in this profession.

❖ GENDER POLICY IN ZIMBABWE

The Zimbabwean government is making frantic efforts to address the gender gap between males and females and improve the social status of the position of women. The following policies are among various gender policies enacted to achieve this goal:

- Maintenance Act
- Equal Pay Act – equal remuneration between men and women with same positions.

- Labour Relations Act – addresses gender imbalances at the workplace on areas like maternity, discrimination etc.
- Domestic Violence Act (2007) – guards against all forms of gender based violence or abuse.
- Education Act (2004)
- Gender Discrimination Act – guards against various forms of discrimination on the basis of gender.
- Matrimonial Causes Act
- Matrimonial Property Act – equal sharing of property
- National Gender Policy e.g. Creation of Gender and Human Rights Commission

However, despite such interventions, most women are still a long from achieving equality with men in most areas of academic, family, political and economic life.

❖ WOMEN AND EMPLOYMENT

• Problems faced by Zimbabwean women in employment

Despite various gender policies and laws protecting the rights of women, women continue to face some challenges at the workplace. These include:

- Sexual abuse/harassment – employers take advantage of the high rate of unemployment in Zimbabwe to ask for sexual favours in return for promotion at work, jobs etc.
- Low chances of promotion to high level posts like managerial work as most employers subscribe to the stereotypical belief about the ‘unsuitability’ of women.
- Pay differences for same work, despite equal pay act legislations.
- Level or type of work e.g. most women are employed in the ‘secondary labour market’ as secretaries etc.
- Hours of work – on average men works for eight hours a day only as compared to several hours worked by women at work and at home.
- Housework – most women are housewives.

• Influence of employment on the social status on the position of women

Modern industrial societies are characterised by increasing working women. This has resulted in:

- Increased economic independence
 - Joint conjugal roles (as opposed to segregated conjugal roles) – Bott.
 - Women emancipation
 - Increase in divorce cases
-

End of topic!!!@corpuschristhigh